

**Tylenol,
a brand of
acetaminophen,
1983**



Painkillers

- **What?** Acetaminophen
- **Who?** Harmon Northrop Morse
- **Where and when?** US, 1877

Sometimes it can take a while for a drug to catch on. In 1877, an American chemist developed the now popular drug acetaminophen, which is usually used as a mild painkiller and flu medication. But unfounded doubts about its safety meant that it wasn't released to the public until 1950.

The miracle drug

- **What?** Aspirin
- **Who?** Felix Hoffman
- **Where and when?** Germany, 1897

Aspirin is used for treating such a wide range of ailments, including headaches, heart attacks, blood clots, and strokes, that it is sometimes known as the “miracle drug.” It is a synthetic form of a natural substance called salicylic acid, which is found in willow bark and has been used to treat illnesses for centuries.



**Carton of
soluble aspirin
powder, 1900**



An iron lung helps a patient to breathe, 1940

Breathing easy

- **What?** Iron lung
- **Who?** Philip Drinker and Dr. Louis Agassiz Shaw
- **Where and when?** US, 1927

Patients whose breathing muscles were paralyzed by an accident or disease could be helped to breathe again with the invention of the iron lung. It was a cumbersome machine—the patient had to be almost entirely enclosed within it—but it saved lives. It has since been replaced by smaller respirators and air ventilators.